

Are you Game?

There are three primary types of controllers—Wheels, Joysticks and Game pads—each of which is best suited to certain game genres. A joystick is the ideal choice for flight simulators while game pads and wheels are better suited for driving games. Most first person action games, on the other hand, are still best played with a mouse and keyboard combination. Microsoft and Logitech might be the big boys but a lot of other smaller brands such as JS Equipments have solid reliable units too.

SMART TIPS

Ergonomics (and Weight): For any input device the most important factor is the feel. This is a combination of the weight, balance and placement of the buttons. However, a badly designed controller can cause discomfort and in some cases even tendonitis.

Buttons: Quality comes before quantity. Before getting overawed by the number of buttons, check whether they feel right and that they are placed conveniently.

Configuration/Drivers:

While a lot of these devices will work with the generic Windows drivers, device-specific drivers will allow you to calibrate, configure and optimise controller performance.

Connector: While the most common connectors use the joystick port that is present in most soundcards (even the onboard ones), USB-compatible devices are becoming increasingly popular.



Build quality:

Make sure that the controller does not have sharp edges. Joysticks and wheels see a lot of rough handling and need to be particularly sturdy.

Fastening mechanism:

Both the steering wheels and joysticks need to be fixed to a stable base. Check that the clamp/suction caps that will attach them to the table are sturdy.



Force feedback: These controllers are much more expensive than regular ones but add considerable realism to the game play in arcade, driving and flight simulation games.

Also Remember...

- A long cable on your controller allows you flexibility in the placement of the device and sufficient mobility for some of the more engrossing games.
- Left-handed users will find that most of the devices are designed primarily for right-handed gamers.
- You can choose between digital and analogue units of which the digital controllers are easier to calibrate and provide a more precise response.

	Steering wheels	Joysticks	Gamepads
You need	Driving games	Flight sims, arcade games	Sports, driving, arcade games
Look for	Sturdy gearshift lever, foot pedals and a strong clamping mechanism. Check for the comfort of the steering grip and easily accessible buttons	Look for at least six configurable buttons, a POV hat and eight-way direction control. Check for sturdy suction caps.	The most important criteria is the comfort of the grip. Also make sure that you have at least 8 buttons in addition to the D-Pad.
Our pick	Logitech WingMan Formula Force Microsoft SideWinder Steering Wheel	Microsoft SideWinder Force Feedback 2.0 Logitech WingMan Extreme Digital 3D	Microsoft PnP Gamepad (USB) JS Equipment
Price range	Rs 6,000 to Rs 9,500	Rs 2,500 to Rs 7,500	Rs 600 to Rs 1,500